Movement & Video Dynamics Prompting (AI-Generated Motion Cheat Sheet)

In short video content, **motion is emotion** – the way the camera moves or how scenes transition can captivate viewers. This section covers how to prompt for **movement** – whether it's simulating camera moves in AI-generated videos or planning dynamic shots that hook the audience. We'll talk about using tools like Runway ML Gen-2, Pika Labs, and leveraging our earlier image tools to create movement. We'll also include tips on editing techniques and how to ensure your video has an engaging flow from start to finish.

Key Principles for Movement in TikToks/Reels:

- **Hook with Movement Early:** In the first 1-3 seconds, try to include some visual motion to grab attention – a quick zoom, a pan, something changing on screen. Studies show that *hooks* (fast visual or auditory teasers) in the first moments significantly boost retentionpodcastle.ai. For example, start with a fast **zoom-out** from a detail to reveal a scene, or a sudden camera cut. In AI terms, you might prompt the first scene to have a dramatic motion (e.g. "camera rapidly pulls back to show…") to mimic that hook. Even a subtle motion, like a light pan or a subject's action, is better than static. *E.g.* a prompt for the opening frame: "A close-up of eyes opening – camera **quickly zooms out** to show a shocked expression."

- **Plan the Camera as You Would the Story:** When writing prompts for video generation, explicitly mention camera movements and angles. Runway Gen-2 and Sora both respond to these cues. Terms like **pan, zoom, tilt, dolly (move in/out), tracking shot, wide-angle, close-up** act as instructions for the AI camera. For instance, *"camera pans from left to right across a busy cafe"* or *"overhead drone shot of a forest, slowly descending"* can be part of your prompt. This is akin to writing a mini shooting script for the AI.

- **Use Action Verbs for Subject Movement:** Similarly, describe what the subject is doing in motion terms: *"running toward the camera," "dancing in a circle," "car drifting around corner."* These **action keywords** inject energyand prompt the AI to render motion (either via motion blur, or sequential frames showing movement). E.g., Runway will attempt to animate the "running" action if you include that, and Pika Labs (image-to-video) will create movement between keyframes if it understands an action is happening.

- **Keep Shots Short and Focused:** AI-generated video, especially Gen-2 or Sora, works best with short scenes. If you need a 15-second video, consider it as e.g. 3 shots of ~5s each. You can prompt and generate these separately, then **edit them together** (using basic video editing or even within Runway's editor or Sora's storyboard feature). This modular approach also lets you re-order or drop shots to improve pacing.